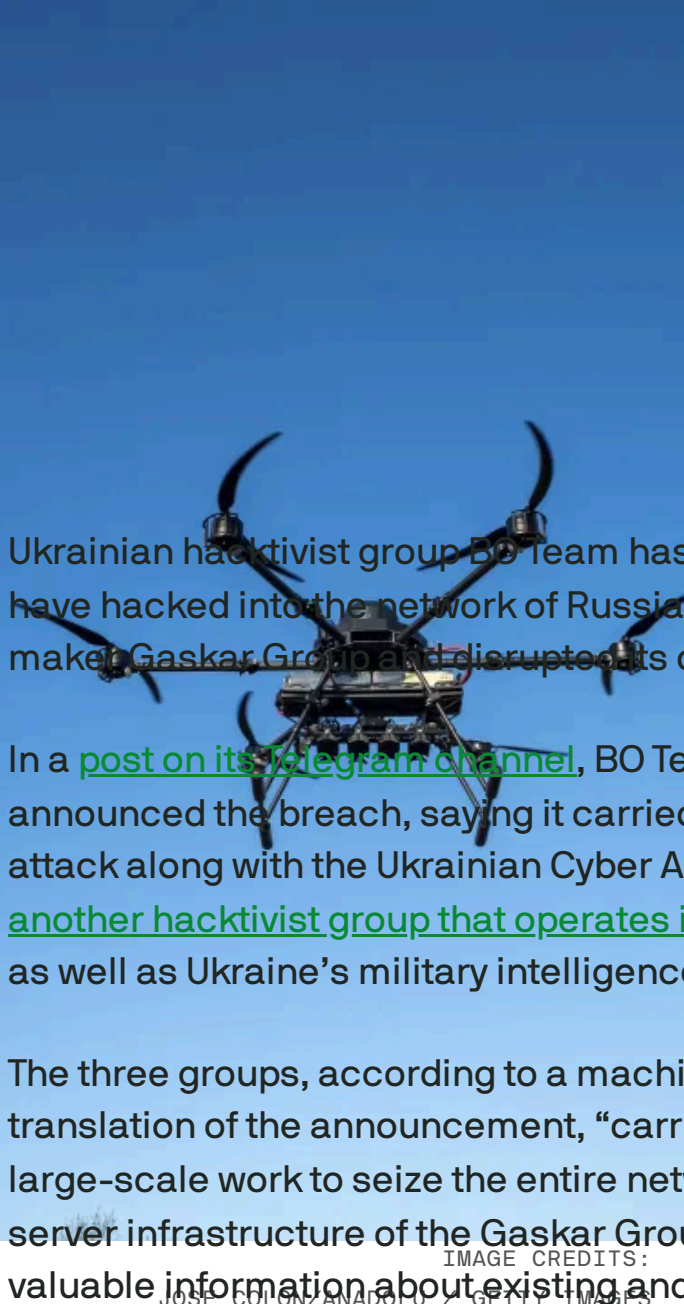


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Ukrainian hackers claim to have destroyed servers of Russian drone maker



Ukrainian hacktivist group BO Team has claimed to have hacked into the network of Russian drone maker Gaskar Group and disrupted its operations.

In a [post on its Telegram channel](#), BO Team announced the breach, saying it carried out the attack along with the Ukrainian Cyber Alliance, [another hacktivist group that operates in Ukraine](#), as well as Ukraine's military intelligence.

The three groups, according to a machine translation of the announcement, “carried out large-scale work to seize the entire network and server infrastructure of the Gaskar Group, collect valuable information about existing and promising [unmanned aerial vehicles], followed by the destruction of information and the disabling of this infrastructure.”

BO Team said that during the cyberattack it destroyed more than 250 systems, including 46 virtual servers and more than 200 workstations, as well as wiping 47 terabytes of company data and 10 terabytes of backups. The hacktivists added that they stole the personal data of Gaskar Group employees, including their home addresses and family information, during the breach.

Both Ukraine and Russian soldiers have extensively used drones since the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. Gaskar Group [reportedly supplies drones](#) to the Russian military.

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Gaskar Group did not immediately respond to a request for comment sent to its official Telegram phone number.

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai is a Senior Writer at TechCrunch, where he covers hacking, cybersecurity,...

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How Ukraine's cyber police fights back against Russia's

Ukraine's cyber police talks crypto, ransomware and documenting war crimes after Russia's invasion

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

7:52 AM PDT · April 12, 2024

On February 24, 2022, Russian forces invaded Ukraine. Since then, life in the country has changed for everyone.

For the Ukrainian forces who had to defend their country, for the regular citizens who had to withstand invading forces and constant shelling, and for the Cyberpolice of Ukraine, which had to shift its focus and priorities.

"Our responsibility changed after the full scale war started," said Yevhenii Panchenko, the chief of division of the Cyberpolice Department of the National Police of Ukraine, during a talk on Tuesday in New York City. "New directives were put under our responsibility."

During the talk at the Chainalysis LINKS conference, Panchenko said that the Cyberpolice is comprised of around a thousand employees, of which about forty track crypto-related crimes. The Cyberpolice's responsibility is to combat "all manifestations of cyber crime in cyberspace," said Panchenko. And after the war started, he said, "we were also responsible for the active struggle against the aggression in cyberspace."

IMAGE CREDITS: KRIS TRIPPLAAR/CHAINALYSTS

Panchenko sat down for a wide-ranging interview with TechCrunch on Wednesday, where he spoke about the Cyberpolice's new responsibilities in wartime Ukraine. That includes tracking what war crimes Russian soldiers are committing in the country, which they sometimes post on social media; monitoring the flow of cryptocurrency funding the war; exposing disinformation campaigns; investigating ransomware attacks; and training citizens on good cybersecurity practices.

The following transcript has been edited for brevity and clarity.

TechCrunch: How did your job and that of the police change after the invasion?



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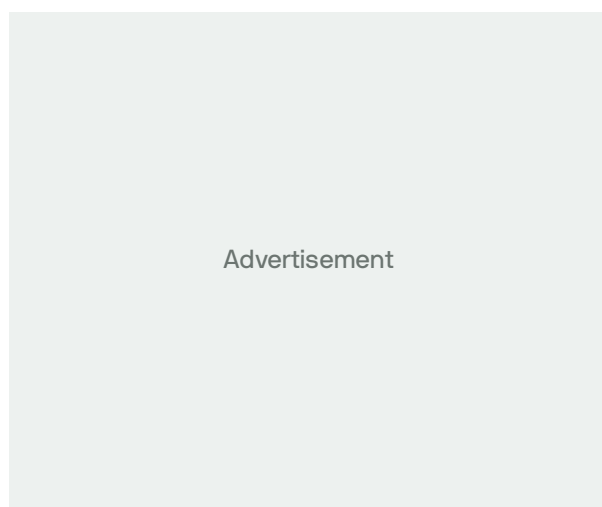
It almost totally changed. Because we still have some regular tasks that we always do, we're responsible for all the spheres of cyber investigation.

We needed to relocate some of our units in different places, of course, to some difficult organizations because now we need to work separately. And also we added some new tasks and new areas for us of responsibilities when the war started.

From the list of the new tasks that we have, we crave information about Russian soldiers. We never did that. We don't have any experience before February 2022. And now we try to collect all the evidence that we have because they also adapted and started to hide, like their social media pages that we used for recognizing people who were taking part in the larger invading forces that Russians used to get our cities and kill our people.

Also, we are responsible for identifying and investigating the cases where Russian hackers do attacks against Ukraine. They attack our infrastructure, sometimes DDoS [distributed denial-of-service attacks], sometimes they make defacements, and also try to disrupt our information in general. So, it's quite a different sphere.

Because we don't have any cooperation with Russian law enforcement, that's why it's not easy to sometimes identify or search information about IP addresses or other things. We need to find new ways to cooperate on how to exchange data with our intelligence services.



Some units are also responsible for defending the critical infrastructure in the cyber sphere. It's also an important task. And today, many attacks also target critical infrastructure. Not only missiles, but hackers also try to get the data and destroy some resources like electricity, and other things.

When we think about soldiers, we think about real world actions. But are there any crimes that Russian soldiers are committing online?

[Russia] uses social media to sometimes take pictures and publish them on the internet, as it was usual in the first stage of the war. When the war first started, probably for three or four months [Russian soldiers] published everything: videos and photos from the cities that were occupied temporarily. That was evidence that we collected.

And sometimes they also make videos when they shoot in a city, or use tanks or other vehicles with really big guns. There's some evidence that they don't choose the target, they just randomly shoot around. It's the video that we also collected and included in investigations that our office is doing against the Russians.

In other words, looking for evidence of war crimes?

Yes.

How has the ransomware landscape in Ukraine changed after the invasion?

It's changed because Russia is now not only focused on the money side; their main target is to show citizens and probably some public sector that [Russia] is really effective and strong. If they have any access on a first level, they don't deep dive, they just destroy the resources and try to deface just to show that they are really strong. They have really effective hackers and groups who are responsible for that. Now, we don't have so many cases related to ransom, we have many cases related to disruption attacks. It has changed in that way.

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Has it been more difficult to distinguish between pro-Russian criminals and Russian government hackers?

Really difficult, because they don't like to look like a government structure or some units in the military. They always find a really fancy name like, I don't know, 'Fancy Bear' again. They try to hide their real nature.

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Do you have information about
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work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram, Keybase and Wire @lorenzofb, or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

But we see that after the war started, their militaries and intelligence services started to organize groups — maybe they're not so effective and not so professional as some groups that worked before the war started. But they organize the groups in a massive [scale]. They start from growing new partners, they give them some small tasks, then see if they are effective and truly succeed in a small portion of IT knowledge. Then they move forward and do some new tasks. Now we can see many of the applications they also publish on the internet about the results. Some are not related to what governments or intelligence groups did, but they publish that intelligence. They also use their own media resources to raise the impact of the attack.

What are pro-Russian hacking groups doing these days? What activities are they focused on? You mentioned critical infrastructure defacements; is there anything else that you're tracking?

It starts from basic attacks like DDoS to destroy communications and try to destroy the channels that we use to communicate. Then, of course, defacements. Also, they collect data. Sometimes they publish that in open sources. And sometimes they probably collect but not use it in disruption, or in a way to show that they already have the access.

Sometimes we know about the situation when we prevent a crime, but also attacks. We have some signs of compromise that were probably used on one government, and then we share with others.

[Russia] also creates many psyops channels. Sometimes the attack did not succeed. And even if they don't have any evidence, they'll say "we have access to the system of military structures of Ukraine."

How are you going after these hackers? Some are not inside the country, and some are inside the country.

That's the worst thing that we have now, but it's a situation that could change. We just need to collect all the evidence and also provide investigation as we can. And also, we inform other law enforcement agencies in countries who

cooperate with us about the actors who we identify as part of the groups that committed attacks on Ukrainian territory or to our critical infrastructure.

Why is it important? Because if you talk about some regular soldier from the Russian army, he will probably never come to the European Union and other countries. But if we talk about some smart guys who already have a lot of knowledge in offensive hacking, he prefers to move to warmer places and not work from Russia. Because he could be recruited to the army, other things could happen. That's why it's so important to collect all evidence and all information about the person, then also prove that he was involved in some attacks and share that with our partners.

Also because you have a long memory, you can wait and maybe identify this hacker, where they are in Russia. You have all the information, and then when they are in Thailand or somewhere, then you can move in on them. You're not in a rush necessarily?

They attack a lot of our civil infrastructure. That war crime has no time expiration. That's why it's so important. We can wait 10 years and then arrest him in Spain or other countries.

Who are the cyber volunteers doing and what is their role?

We don't have many people today who are volunteers. But they are really smart people from around the world — the United States and the European Union. They also have some knowledge in IT, sometimes in blockchain analysis. They help us to provide analysis against the Russians, collect data about the wallets that they use for fundraising campaigns, and sometimes they also inform us about the new form or new group that the Russians create to coordinate their activities.

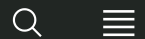
It's important because we can't cover all the things that are happening. Russia is a really big country, they have many groups, they have many people involved in the war. That type of cooperation with volunteers is really important now, especially because they also have a better knowledge of local languages.

Sometimes we have volunteers who are really close to Russian-speaking countries. That helps us understand what exactly they are doing. There is also a community of IT guys that's also communicating with our volunteers directly. It's important and we really like to invite other people to that activity.

It's not illegal or something like that. They just provide the information and they can tell us what they can do.

What about pro-Ukrainian hackers [like the Ukraine IT Army](#). Do you just let

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They also have a lot of impact with that, because if they launder and take money from our citizens, we could help. And that's why we include those activities, so we proactively react to stories that we received from our citizens, from our partners about new types of fraud that could be happening on the internet.

And also we provide some training for our citizens about cyber hygiene and cybersecurity. It's also important today because the Russians hackers not only target the critical infrastructure or government structures, they also try to get some data of our people.

For example, Telegram. Now it's not a big problem but it's a new challenge for us, because they first send interesting material, and ask people to communicate or interact with bots. On Telegram, you can create bots. And if you just type twice, they get access to your account, and change the number, change two-factor authentication, and you will lose your account.

Is fraud done to raise funds for the war?

Yes.

Can you tell me more about Russian fundraising? Where are they doing it, and who is giving them money? Are they using the blockchain?

There are some benefits and also disadvantages that crypto could give them. First of all, [Russians] use crypto a lot. They create almost all kinds of wallets. It starts from Bitcoin to Monero. Now they understand that some types of crypto are really dangerous for them because many of the exchanges cooperate and also confiscate the funds that they collect to help their military.

How are you going after this type of fundraising?

If they use crypto, we label the addresses, we make some attribution. It's our main goal. That's also the type of activities that our volunteers help us to do. We are really effective at that. But if they use some banks, we only could collect the data and understand who exactly is responsible for that campaign. Sanctions are the only good way to do that.

What is cyber resistance?

Cyber resistance is the big challenge for us. We wanted to play that cyber resistance in cyberspace for our users, for our resources. First of all, if we talk about users, we start from training and also sharing some advice and knowledge with our citizens. The idea is how you could react to the attacks that are expected in the future.

How is the Russian government using crypto after the invasion?

Russia didn't change everything in crypto. But they adapted because they saw that there were many sanctions. They create new ways to launder money to prevent attribution of the addresses that they used for their infrastructures, and to pay or receive funds. It's really easy in crypto to create many addresses. Previously they didn't do that as much, but now they use it often.

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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

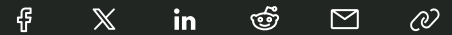
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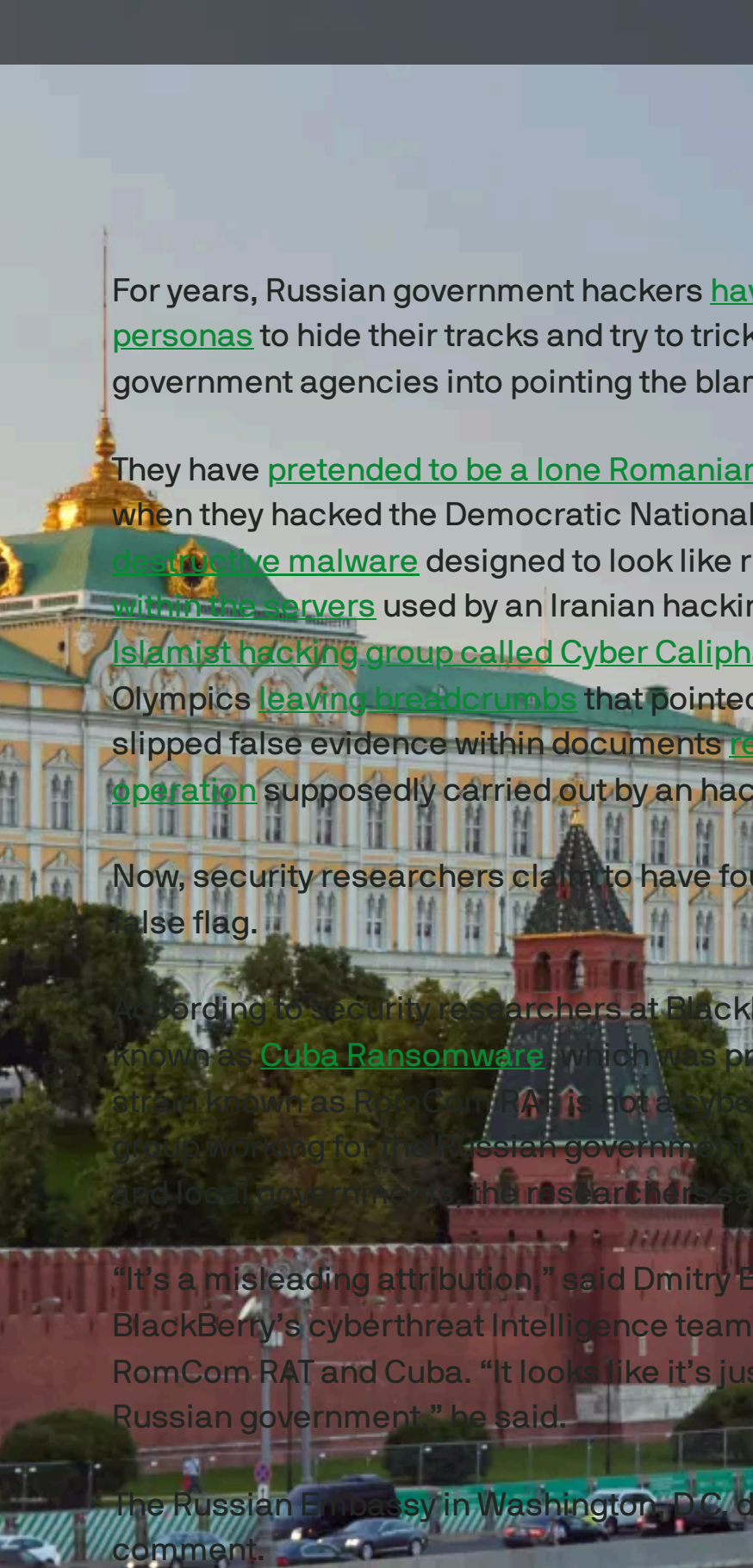


Cybercriminals who targeted Ukraine are actually Russian government hackers, researchers say

A hacking group believed to be interested in ransomware and cybercrime may actually be a front for Russian government hackers

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

8:39 AM PDT · May 15, 2023

The background image shows the Russian Embassy in Washington, D.C., a large, ornate building with a green roof and gold accents. In the foreground, there is a red brick wall and a street with cars. The image is partially obscured by a green vertical bar on the right side.

For years, Russian government hackers [have used several made-up personas](#) to hide their tracks and try to trick security researchers and government agencies into pointing the blame in the wrong direction.

They have [pretended to be a lone Romanian hacker](#) called Guccifer 2.0 when they hacked the Democratic National Committee; unleashed [a destructive malware](#) designed to look like run-of-the-mill ransomware; [hid within the servers](#) used by an Iranian hacking group; claimed to be [an Islamist hacking group called Cyber Caliphate](#); hacked the 2018 Winter Olympics [leaving breadcrumbs](#) that pointed to North Korea and China; and slipped false evidence within documents [released as a hack and leak operation](#) supposedly carried out by an hacker group called Cyber Berkut.

Now, security researchers claim to have found a new Russian government false flag.

According to security researchers at BlackBerry, the cybercrime group known as [Cuba Ransomware](#) which was previously linked to a malware strain known as RomCom RAT is not a cybercrime group at all. It's actually a group working for the Russian government targeting Ukrainian military units and local governments, the researchers said.

"It's a misleading attribution," said Dmitry Bestuzhev, senior director of BlackBerry's cyberthreat Intelligence team, referring to the links between RomCom RAT and Cuba. "It looks like it's just another unit working for the Russian government," he said.

The Russian Embassy in Washington, D.C. did not respond to a request for comment.

IMAGE CREDITS: MAX RYAZANOV / GETTY IMAGES

RomCom RAT is a remote access trojan [first discovered by Unit 42](#), the Palo Alto Networks security research group, in May 2022. The company's security researchers linked the malware to the Cuba gang, which has used ransomware against targets in the sectors of "financial services, government facilities, healthcare and public health, critical manufacturing, and information technology," [according to U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA](#).



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The name comes from the group itself, which used [illustrations of Fidel Castro and Che Guevara](#) on its dark web site, although no researcher has ever found any evidence that the group has anything to do with the island nation.

RomCom RAT has reportedly [used fake versions of popular apps](#) to target its victims, such as the password manager KeePass, the IT administration tool SolarWinds, Advanced IP Scanner and Adobe Acrobat reader. Over the last few months, according to Bestuzhev and his colleagues, RomCom RAT also targeted Ukrainian military units, local government agencies and Ukraine's parliament.

Bestuzhev explained that their conclusion is not just based on the targets, but also on the timing of the hackers' operations.

His team have tracked the group for a year and followed its trail through the internet. As part of their investigation, the researchers observed the hackers using different digital certificates to register the fake domains they used to plant malware on targets.

In one case, the researchers witnessed the hackers creating an Austria-presenting digital certificate to sign a booby-trapped website on March 23, a week before Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy [addressed the Austrian parliament](#) via video call.

The same pattern happened other times. When the RomCom RAT hackers mimicked a SolarWinds website in November 2022, it was around the time Ukrainian forces [entered the besieged city of Kherson](#). When the hackers mimicked Advanced IP Scanner in July 2022, it was just as Ukraine began

[deploying HIMARS rockets](#) supplied by the U.S. government. And then in March 2023, the hackers mimicked Remote Desktop Manager around the time Ukrainian pilots [were getting trained to fly F-16 fighter jets](#), and Poland and Slovakia [decided to provide](#) Ukraine with military tech.

“So each time a major event happened, like something big in geopolitics, and especially on the military field, RomCom RAT was just there, just right there,” Bestuzhev said.

Other security researchers, as well as the Ukrainian government itself, however, are still not fully convinced RomCom RAT and Cuba Ransomware are actually Russian government hackers.

Doel Santos, a senior researcher at Palo Alto Networks’ Unit 42, said that the group behind the RomCom RAT malware is “more sophisticated than traditional ransomware groups,” for its use of custom tools.

“Unit 42 has seen the activity targeting Ukraine. There is an espionage angle with this and because of that, they could be getting direction from a nation state,” Santos told TechCrunch. “However, we don’t know the extent of that relationship. It goes outside the normal activities of a ransomware group.”

Still, Santos added, “some groups moonlight to get additional work — this may be what we’re seeing in this case.”

Bestuzhev said he and his team have considered this possibility but have excluded it based on the hackers’ persistence, the timing and targets of the attacks, which indicate their real goal is espionage and not crime.

A spokesperson for the [State Special Communications Service of Ukraine](#), or SSSCIP, said that [one of RomCom RAT’s operations in Ukraine](#) targeted users of a specific situational awareness software called DELTA, and “according to the target and used malware, it can be assumed that the goal was collecting intelligence from the Ukraine military.”

“But there is not enough evidence to connect it with Russia (except the fact that Russia is the most interested government in such kind of information),” an SSSCIP spokesperson added.

Mark Karayan, a spokesperson for Google’s threat intelligence teams, who have been tracking the hacking group, said that “our team can’t confidently confirm or deny these findings without seeing [BlackBerry’s] full research.”

Bestuzhev said that his group doesn't plan on publishing all the technical details of their findings, in an attempt to not show their hand to RomCom RAT hackers, and prevent them from changing their strategies and techniques. This way, Bestuzhev explained, they can keep tracking the hackers and see what they do next.

The jury is still out on who's really behind RomCom RAT and Cuba Ransomware, but Bestuzhev and researchers from other companies will continue to keep an eye on the group.

"Those guys, let's say, they know we know. We love each other. And so it's like a long-term relationship," Bestuzhev said, laughing.

Do you have more information about this hacking group? Or other hacking groups involved in the war in Ukraine? We'd love to hear from you. You can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Wickr, Telegram and Wire @lorenzofb, or email lorenzo@techcrunch.com. You can also contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

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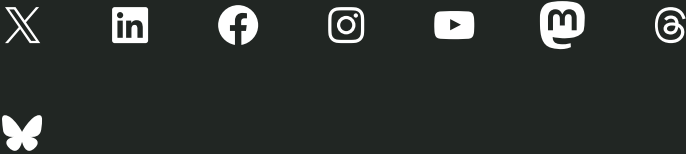
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